



Aligning Department X's Talent Management with Company X's Strategic Goals

Team 1: Amandil Fidaleo, Augustin Pollaouec, Juliana Escallón Rosselli, Laura Herrera

Mora

IE University

HR Fundamentals

Rocio Bonet

November 22, 2025

Introduction

Company X and Department X are placeholder names to maintain anonymity

Company X is fundamentally an entertainment company with its primary goal to create experiences that drive guest happiness. However, as Manager 1 explains, “like any corporation, it’s about making money, making shareholders happy, but it’s a function of creating entertainment that people enjoy and consume.” Thus, the overarching brand of the company is described as “magical”—built upon storytelling that appeals to both children and adults bringing dreams and imagination to reality.

The value proposition of this company originates from its orientation around guest experience, overall brand reputation, recognition, and loyalty. The corporation differentiates itself by constantly innovating, keeping up with trends, promoting diversity and equity, mixing culture, integrating technological advancements, and creating unique experiences. This organizational strategy is a multifaceted approach, emphasizing arenas that reinforce the brand’s ecosystem including media and entertainment, consumer experiences, and merchandise/products across global markets. Through acquisitions, alliances, and internal development the organization is able to grow and expand its reach within its sectors.

Company X would not be as successful as it is without the technology and innovation teams who make the “magic.” We will focus on a division of Company X that works behind the scenes to make this possible: Department X that consists of research and development, technology and engineering for the organization. The goal of this part of the organization is to “use differential thinking to deliver exponential value to the organization” (Manager 1). Through new ideas and technical innovation like Artificial Intelligence (herein “AI”), robotics, reinforcement learning, etc., Department X attempts to solve Company X’s creative and operational challenges. The department bridges creative ideas and innovation with research, engineering and technology to enhance the storytelling and guest experience.

This objective cannot create real progression and change within the company independently. The employees and management of talent play a significant part in the execution of this goal. Talent management encompasses the process of planning and shaping the progression of individuals within the organization according to several aspects: the organization's goals, the employees performance and potential, and the individual goals and preferences. Successful talent management includes *hiring well*, *motivating*, and *retaining* the individuals meaningfully to create value for the organization.

Are there ways talent management could be handled differently in order to create this “exponential value?” Is the department attracting and hiring the best people? Is it motivating and developing the talent or is it losing talented people to competitors? By analyzing the department’s talent management practices, we aim to answer these questions and provide suggestions to extend their current practices that align with the overall guest-centric mission of the company.

Methodology

We interviewed two managers and the Senior Human Resources Business Partner to get primary insights on how the division approaches talent management. We combined this with online research of Company X’s public talent management information and business strategies as well as research on competitor’s practices to develop our suggestions.

Department X- Hiring & Attraction

As a highly technical and creative group, it is extremely important that the ideal people are hired and top talent is obtained. Official processes are very decentralized and manager-driven with HR providing a limited structure. Hiring is generally initiated by project

needs and specific technical gaps. Line managers assess portfolios that consist of real-world projects that demonstrate the success of their abilities.

The skills are important, but the department also looks for many attributes beyond the proof of skill prioritizing interpersonal fit. Cultural and behavioral alignment are heavily weighted as they “do a lot more interviewing based on vibes and fit” (Manager 1). They look for people who can adapt, who are curious, who have a passion for building and problem solving, and those who work well in a team.

Problem - Hiring & Attraction

In order to hire well, an organization needs to be attracting the best talent. Publicly, Company X values creativity and entertainment, so for Department X it is hard to attract top technical talent. From an employee perspective, Company X is not a “tech company” and would not offer the same technological benefits and progressions as other companies like Universal Creative, Google, Meta, Apple, NVIDIA, and Epic Games. Through internships, Company X is able to show entry level talent the technical opportunities within the organization, but without this internal exposure and explanation, it is hard to attract externally. Many potential candidates, especially the technical talent, do not know what kinds of projects exist within Department X until they have already interned. This poses a problem when Company X is not even on the radar for technical talent when assessing different jobs and careers.

When hiring, Company X lacks standardized processes compared to competitors which leads to inconsistent hiring standards across departments. The hiring is often led by the creative or technical leaders rather than HR which results in decisions reflecting personal preferences instead of organizational strategy. The HRBP noted that they can “advise” but do not always control final hiring decisions. Past hires have shown that the leaders have

preferred people with personalities that fit existing team culture but may not be what is needed from an overall strategic perspective. This approach may limit innovation and diversity of thought, reinforcing groupthink.

Suggestions - Hiring & Attraction

The first problem that needs to be addressed before the talent can even be “managed,” is attracting the best. There is a clear need for better external branding of the department’s technical aspect. Company X and Department X need to highlight the significance technological roles play in the organization and target niche markets to broaden the scope of attraction. While they are fundamentally an entertainment company, emphasizing its reliance on behind the scenes creative technology innovation creates desirability for technical talent to be part of the mission to create unique guest experiences. Through public campaigns or features that highlight the use of AI, robotics, and research and development (herein “R&D”) in combination with featured employee stories showcasing how their innovation directly impacts the broader organization will put Company X on the radar for potential employees.

To standardize and align hiring processes, Department X must develop a more structured hiring framework for the department and tech driven areas of the organization to ensure that each hire can deliver the most value to the company. (*see Exhibit 1*)

Department X- Motivation

In Department X, employees' motivation is strongly derived intrinsically and intellectually. From the perspective of HR, detailed career frameworks and learning platforms have been created as tools for managers to use in discussion with the employees when creating tailored development plans. Both managers explained how motivation comes from

creative feedback and impact as employees are driven by the ability to “create magic” through innovation.

The managers are encouraged to act as coaches for their employees and hold continuous development conversations instead of just relying on annual reviews. This is already consistent with modern motivational frameworks like job enrichment and goal setting. (McEvoy & Cascio, 1985)

Problem - Motivation

Despite the drive from intrinsic motivation, the interviewees expressed how development and attention to each individual employee is unevenly distributed. As the HRBP explained, “We definitely poured more into the two ends of the bell curve...the high potentials and underperformers.” This leaves the core majority of the employees less supported which could potentially lead to disengagement if they see limited differentiation in recognition or progression. In addition, there is heavy reliance on intrinsic motivation; the lack of formal incentives and structured reward systems could pose a problem—especially for technical talent where some seek clearer growth and recognition.

Suggestions - Motivation

Motivation is a large aspect of talent management as it fosters sustained engagement and can be used strategically to link personal growth and creativity to increase value for the organization. Communicating clear, non-monetary rewards can strengthen the motivation. This can include opportunities to lead projects, collaborate across teams or present innovations to increase individual visibility keeps the incentives tied to driving creative, innovative solutions. Providing access to mentorship programs or exclusive learning opportunities like R&D summits could be another idea for symbolic rewards. Hackman &

Oldham (1975) identified five job characteristics that influence motivation: *skill variety, task identity, task significance, autonomy, and feedback*. Manager 2 identified that *skill variety, autonomy and task significance* are strengths within the division. Employees regularly apply creative and technical skills with individual freedom to define project directions and select the methods in creation.

“The value of seeing guests smile and their happiness is a measurement of success that is extremely motivational” - Manager 2

To strengthen and sustain this motivation, Department X should build on these natural drivers while addressing the gaps in feedback and development. Providing leadership training focused on these two with an outline of the skills managers should gain can help with this.
(see Exhibit 2)

Department X- Retention

All three interviewees (both managers and HRBP) highlighted the tight-knit, community culture.

“It’s a community that thrives on curiosity and support. People help each other out because they want to see great ideas come to life. That’s why folks stay, because they’re part of something bigger” - Manager 1

“We’ve built this environment where people genuinely love working together. It’s not just about the projects; it’s about the people you get to do them with. There’s a lot of trust and shared history here, and that’s what keeps people coming back” - Manager 2

“There’s a closeness here you don’t find everywhere else. People care deeply about what they do and about each other. That’s what makes the work special. It’s not about the project, it’s about doing it together” - HRBP

This department thrives on the personal connection aligning with *social capital* theories that emphasize how retention is built upon trust and relationships rather than transactional rewards. The culture functions like a creative community centered around belonging and shared enthusiasm for innovation. (Prusack & Cohen, 2001)

Problem - Retention

While working in a collaborative, community team is appealing, it doesn't eliminate all retention challenges. There are several factors that increase turnover risk: unclear growth opportunities and competitors' offers are more appealing. First, market competition: Company and Division X cannot compete with the market salaries. This makes it much easier for competitors who offer higher salaries to retain or even attract top talent.

Secondly, Manager 1 describes how it is hard to align Company X's creative, project-based career paths with linear growth expectations of standard technical professionals. Competitors of this talent offer technical advancement with clearer, faster growth ladders. There are unclear growth opportunities for technical staff as they often hit career ceilings.

Suggestions - Retention

Addressing base salary and monetary aspects of compensation is difficult and requires restructuring systems deeply rooted in the organization; however, building upon *social capital* can help reduce the disparity between competitors. Adding to the existing community culture, Department X could adopt SAS's philosophy of relational retention to strengthen internal networks and recognition to deepen employees' sense of belonging. Hosting regular lunches, creative exchanges or "coffee with a colleague" sessions that connect employees across projects cultivates the culture of warmth and trust.

The HRBP described resources that are currently being developed to help with building career development pathways. These frameworks outline growth opportunities by skill domain and role type showing both technical and creative pathways for advancement. Once these are fully implemented and managers are trained on how to use them in discussion with employees, growth opportunities should be more clear.

What Competitors Are Doing

Across the creative technology world, Company X competes with organizations whose recruitment systems tend to be more structured, better resourced and deeply recognized within technical communities. Understanding how these competitors operate is essential for interpreting the external pressures that influence talent attraction and retention for Department X. Universal Creative, Big Tech firms such as Google, Meta, Apple and NVIDIA, and game-technology leaders like Epic Games all build strong pipelines that target the same mix of designers, engineers, and creative technologists that Company X depends on. Their strategies show a clear pattern: they engage technical talent early, offer transparent and clear pathways for career growth, and invest heavily in employer branding that positions them as technological leaders.

Universal Creative is especially similar to Company X because it also blends creativity with engineering. However, its recruitment systems are more formalized and consistently communicated. The division offers cohort-based internships and regular creative auditions, which give students and emerging professionals clear and structured ways to enter the organization. These programs not only highlight Universal's large-scale projects but also help candidates visualize long-term career trajectories within themed entertainment. Although Company X also reaches early-career talent through internships and competitions, Universal's

narrower technical focus and stronger positioning as an engineering-driven creative studio make it more visible to candidates looking for roles that combine design and technology.

Big Tech companies operate on a different scale altogether. Google, Meta, Apple and NVIDIA maintain global recruitment pipelines with defined research internships, PhD fellowships, and university partnerships that continuously channel early-career talent into highly technical roles (Google Research, n.d.; Meta, n.d.-a; Apple, 2025-a; NVIDIA, n.d.). Their evaluation processes are similarly systematic. Meta and Google, for instance, rely on multi-round interviews, standardized rubrics, and algorithmic or technical assessments to ensure consistency and predictive validity (Meta, n.d.-b; Google Research, n.d.). These companies differentiate themselves by offering research freedom, access to high-performance infrastructure, and globally competitive compensation packages; factors that have intensified due to rising demand for AI expertise, with industry salaries reaching premium levels (Financial Times, 2025; Business Insider, 2025). Relative to these firms, Company X's manager-driven, portfolio-based approach is more personalized but lacks the structure and visibility that technical candidates increasingly expect.

Epic Games is a smaller competitor for Department X, but still matters for some specific roles; mainly those connected to real-time simulations, interactive systems, or visualization technologies. The company expects strong portfolios and is very transparent about the technical skills required for each position, which helps candidates understand whether they are truly ready to apply. Even though the overlap with Department X is much narrower than with Big Tech companies, Epic's reputation in real-time interaction and simulation can still attract candidates with these specialized skills.

Together, these competitors shape a market where early-career pipelines, compensation, and research branding significantly influence candidate decisions. Company X's unique value lies in its purpose-driven project, where innovations translate into

real-world guest experiences, a clear differentiator that few Big Tech or gaming firms can match. To align with its broader R&D and innovations goals, Company X will need to communicate this purpose more effectively, clarify pathways for technical progression, and reinforce the creative-technical identity that distinguishes Department X from research-first or purely entertainment-focused competitors.

Conclusion of Suggestions

The broader HR system and talent management practices must align internally and externally. Baron and Kreps (1999) argues that HR systems must create both internal and external fit to support organizational strategy and context. (*see Exhibit 3*) External refers to the larger business and technological context. Department X's role is to utilize technology and research to bring value to the organization. Therefore, the talent systems should attract, motivate and retain people who have the technical skills but also creativity and collaboration to fuel Company X's competitive advantage. Internally, the HR practices must be mutually reinforcing, so linking hiring criteria, performance feedback and career development under a competency framework that clearly defines values increases "internal consistency" which decreases contradictions between what the firm expects, rewards and promotes.

While insights can be gained by looking at what competitors are doing, misalignment often occurs when organizations try to copy these "best practices" without understanding broader context and the relationship between the systems and the business's strategy. It is important to benchmark and draw on the successful initiatives competitors are implementing, but also modify them to keep Company X's goals and strategy intact.

The visibility towards potential employees gives other companies the biggest advantage as they invest in brand visibility within technical ecosystems. As mentioned previously, Department X, and the technologically focused areas of the organization need to

increase their marketing to attract the best people. Drawing from Universal Creative's project showcases, hosting portfolio days or open innovation outside talent can see the unique blend of art and engineering Company X offers. From Big Tech like Google, Meta, Apple and NVIDIA, establishing proactive university pipelines ensures visibility of the company leading to a steady inflow of technological talent. Epic Game's transparency and skill alignment should be used as a model in combination with the existing career frameworks so employees have a clear understanding of goals and pathways.

To fulfill Company X's mission of creating "magical" experiences that drive guest happiness, Department X must ensure that its talent management systems fully align. Technology serves as a supporting enabler, but is not the end goal of the corporation. Innovation is only valuable when it supports the consumer or entertainment experience which is aligned with the company's mission to bring joy and happiness to the guests. That being said, these people make up the backbone of the organization, driving the creativity and innovation that sustains and increases consumer willingness to pay which in turn increases profits.

The department's ability to "deliver exponential value" depends on its capacity to attract, motivate, and retain the best technical and creative talent. Proposed suggestions strengthen this alignment across these three core areas:

1. Hiring & Attraction: Enhance external branding and apply more structured hiring frameworks.
2. Motivation: Introduce symbolic rewards and strengthen feedback and recognition through leadership training.
3. Retention: Build upon collaborative culture by encouraging cross-team relationships and implementation of career driven frameworks.

Overall, managers need more training and support to carry out the talent management practices. With the improvisations to existing talent management systems and processes, Department X can strengthen its role as a strategic driver of creativity, imagination and technology, ensuring that the innovations continue to enhance storytelling and deliver memorable guest experiences.

Word Count: 2969

Exhibit 1:

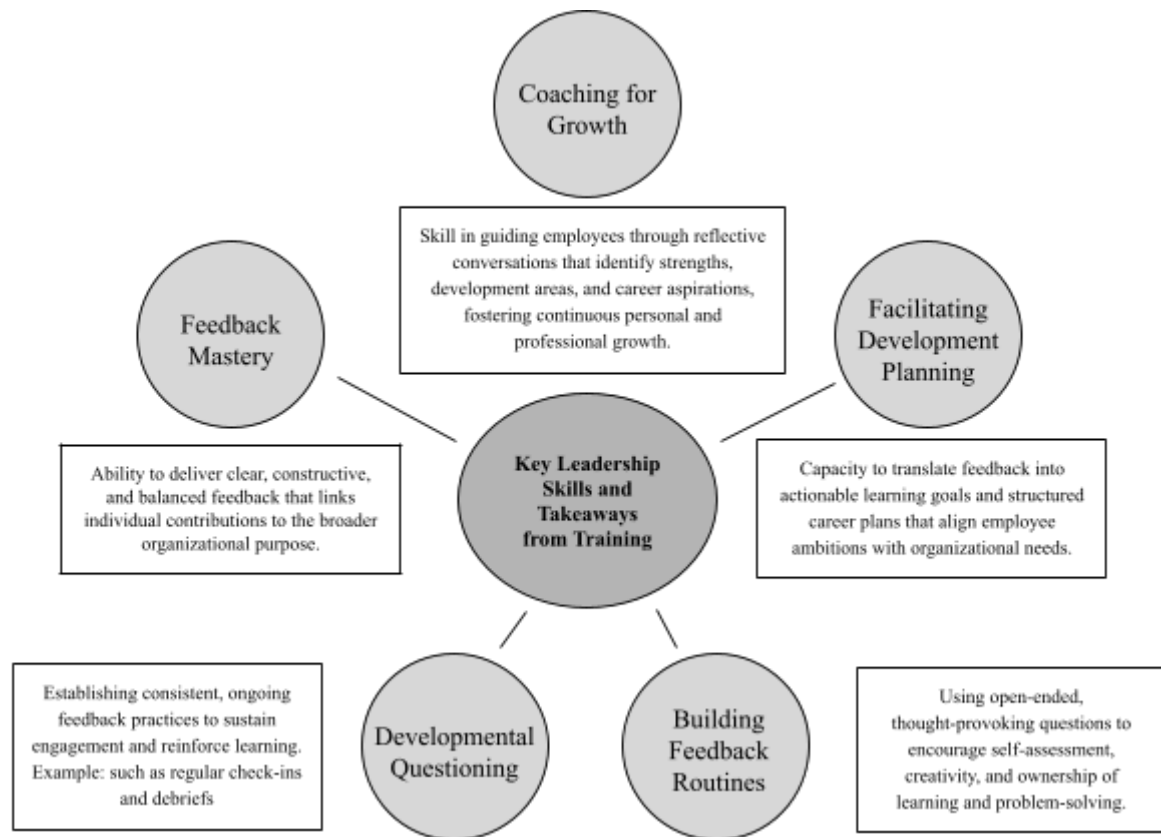
Structured Hiring Framework Suggestion

Stage	Objectives	Key Activities	Tools/Criteria
Stage 1: Workforce Planning & Role Definition	Align each hire with strategic project needs and future capabilities	- Quarterly workforce planning sessions between HRBP, stake leaders, and project managers - Define roles not just by immediate project tasks, but by innovation capabilities	- Strategic skills matrix - Future capabilities map
Stage 2: Job Profiling & Branding	Communicate clear role purpose and attract the right audience	- Create role narratives linking the position to storytelling and guest experience - Highlight creativity + technical impact in job posts	"Story-driven" job descriptions - Consistent brand language
Stage 3: Sourcing & Outreach	Broaden reach and raise visibility among technical talent	- Partner with universities and research institutions - Leverage internal ambassadors to share projects publicly - Tap niche networks	Technical community partnerships
Stage 4: Screening & Shortlisting	Ensure fairness and alignment with role competencies and values	- Initial screen by Talent Acquisition using structured checklist - Standardized evaluation rubric for all candidates - Portfolio and technical test review	Scoring rubric with weighted dimensions: Example: Technical Skill (40%), Creativity & Innovation (30%), Collaboration & Values Fit (30%)
Stage 5: Multi-Panel Interview	Assess technical depth, creative mindset, and cultural fit	- Panel 1: Technical Assessment (hands-on problem-solving or project discussion) - Panel 2: Cross-functional panel (creative + engineering) exploring problem-solving approaches - Panel 3: Values and culture interview led by HR and senior leader	- Behaviorally anchored interview guide - Creative problem scenarios
Stage 6: Candidate Scoring & Calibration	Ensure objectivity and consistency in selection	- Each interviewer submits an independent rating - HRBP facilitates calibration meeting to reconcile scores and discuss evidence-based fit - Final decision documented and justified	5-point scoring system across all criteria - Candidate evaluation summary form
Stage 7: Offer & Onboarding	Translate attraction into retention through culture immersion	- Communicate offer emphasizing growth and impact on storytelling - Tailor onboarding around Department X's culture: project immersion, mentorship, and innovation showcase	90-day onboarding plan - Buddy/mentor assignment

Note: Outline of a proposed structured hiring framework designed to standardize Department X's recruitment practices and align talent selection to enhance value to the organization.

Exhibit 2:

Suggested Key Leadership Skills and Takeaways from Manager Training



Note: Illustration showing key leadership skills gained through feedback and development training to enable managers to foster intrinsic motivation across Department X.

Exhibit 3

“Fit” Framework (Baron & Krep’s, 1999)

	Current State (Findings)	Fit Type	Recommended Action	Expected Strategic Impact
Hiring & Attraction	- Decentralized, manager-driven selection - Inconsistent evaluation standards across teams - Weak external branding of technical roles	External	- Develop a structured, competency-based hiring framework that balances creativity, collaboration, and technical depth - Strengthen external employer branding - Formalize HR’s advisory role to ensure strategic alignment across studios	- Strengthens alignment between talent acquisition and business strategy. - Improves candidate quality and cultural match. - Enhances reputation among top technical talent.
Motivation	- Intrinsic motivation strong (“creating magic”) - Uneven development focus; resources concentrated on high and low performers, middle neglected - Limited structured feedback and recognition mechanisms	Internal	- Implement structured leadership coaching and feedback programs - Utilize the tailored development paths that reflect both creative and technical growth trajectories	- Strengthens a culture of continuous learning and innovation - Enhances engagement and perceived fairness - Links motivation directly to strategic creativity and performance
Retention	- Over reliance on social cohesion for retention; weak career pathing undermines long-term employee commitment - Pay structure and progression systems inconsistent with talent expectations	Both	- Clarify career frameworks and dual paths (technical & creative) - Introduce symbolic and purpose-driven rewards (visibility, learning summits, project leadership) - Integrate retention plans into succession and talent development strategy	- Increases retention of high-potential talent - Reinforces innovation culture through purpose-driven engagement - Creates sustainable internal mobility aligned with strategic goals
Overall Alignment	Strong culture of creativity and passion, but fragmented systems create inequity and inefficiency	Internal	Develop an integrated talent management system that links recruitment, development, and retention to shared competencies (innovation, collaboration, adaptability)	- Achieves systemic coherence across the employee lifecycle - Enhances agility, equity, and strategic execution

Note: Applying Baron and Krep’s (1999) framework of internal and external fit to

Department X’s talent management practices demonstrating how alignment can have strategic impact on the organization.

References:

- Baron, J. N., & Kreps, D. M. (1999). *Strategic human resources: Frameworks for general managers*. Wiley.
- Hackman, J. R., & Oldham, G. R. (1975). Development of the job diagnostic survey. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 60(2), 159–170.
- McEvoy, G. M., & Cascio, W. F. (1985). Strategies for reducing employee turnover. *Journal of Applied Psychology*, 70(2), 342–353.
- Prusak, L., & Cohen, D. (2001). How to invest in social capital. *Harvard Business Review*, 79(6), 86–97.
- Apple. (2025–a). *Machine learning & AI—Applied research jobs*.
<https://jobs.apple.com/en-us/search?team=applied-research-MLAI-AR>
- Backhaus, K., & Tikoo, S. (2004). Conceptualizing and researching employer branding. *Career Development International*, 9(4–5), 501–517.
<https://doi.org/10.1108/13620430410550754>
- Epic Games. (n.d.). *Early careers—Portfolio requirement for art/visual roles*.
<https://www.epicgames.com/site/en-US/earlycareers/career-paths>
- Financial Times. (2025, July). *AI talent wars lead to superstar salaries for top tech staff*.
<https://www.ft.com/content/d48e7cfe-7b04-4cdd-8769-c88c83522118>
- Google Research. (n.d.). *Careers—Internships and roles*. <https://research.google/careers/>
- Meta. (n.d.–a). *Research internships*. <https://www.metacareers.com/careerprograms/research>
- Pfeffer, J. (1998). *The Human Equation: Building Profits by Putting People First*. Harvard Business School Press.
- NVIDIA. (n.d.). *University recruiting*.
<https://www.nvidia.com/en-us/about-nvidia/careers/university-recruiting/>